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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

DOJ inquiry spurs Fed's defenders

Backlash to scrutiny of Powell cites risks for bank, economy

By Christopher Rugaber and Josh Boak
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration's criminal investigation of Federal Reserve Chair Jerome Powell appeared Monday to be emboldening defenders of the U.S. central bank against the efforts of President Donald Trump to control the Fed.

The backlash reflected the

bigger stakes of a contest about the fate of the Fed's independence, the balance of power within the federal government and the path of the U.S. economy. Trump has long publicly lashed out against Powell for not slashing the Fed's benchmark interest rates to his liking, but the prospect of a criminal indictment was a step too far for an institution that has an outsized influence on inflation and the job market.

Several Republican senators have condemned the Department of Justice's subpoenas of the Fed, which Powell revealed Sunday and characterized as "pretexts" to pressure him to sharply cut interest rates as Trump has demanded. Powell also said the Justice Department has threatened criminal indictments over his June testimony to Congress about the cost and design elements of a building renovation.

Trump has repeatedly used investigations — which might or might not lead to an actual indictment — to attack his political rivals, including Fed governor Lisa Cook, New York Attorney General Letitia James and James Comey, the former FBI director.

White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt told reporters that Trump did not direct his Justice Department to investigate Powell.

"One thing for sure, the president's made it quite clear, is Jerome



Chair Jerome Powell speaks at the Federal Reserve on Dec. 10 in Washington, D.C.
JACQUELYN MARTIN/AP

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Illinois Supreme Court justice retiring

Mary Jane Theis served four decades on the bench

By Jeremy Gorner
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — Mary Jane Theis became a judge in 1983, a few weeks before the biggest, most sweeping judicial corruption scandal in Cook County history came to a head.

Operation Greylord resulted in about 100 indictments and the conviction of more than a dozen judges. And throughout a career that eventually saw Theis elected to the Illinois Supreme Court and serve as chief justice, she said the scandal was a constant reminder that the judiciary in Illinois had once been a national disgrace and that judges must approach their roles with integrity, humility, and honesty.

"Judges must be competent and committed to the highest ethical standards," she wrote in a letter to her colleagues on the high court. "We know that being a judge is not just another job — it is an awesome responsibility."

On Monday, Theis, 76, announced that her historic judicial career was coming to a close and that she will retire from the state Supreme Court on Jan. 29 after serving more than four decades as a judge on all levels, including more than 15 years on the high court. One of five Democratic justices on the seven-judge panel, Theis served as chief justice of the Supreme Court from 2022 until her term for that role expired last year and she returned to being a regular justice.

Theis' retirement allowed the high court to appoint 1st District Appellate Court Justice Sanjay T. Taylor, also a Democrat, as Theis'

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Members of the congregation applaud for Joliet Bishop Ronald Hicks during a farewell Mass at the Cathedral of St. Raymond Nonnatus in Joliet on Sunday. ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The faithful gather to bid a farewell

Bishop Ronald Hicks celebrates final mass in Joliet as he heads to New York

By Jeff Vorva | Chicago Tribune

Elwood's Mary Ann Cockream loves to listen to Bishop Ronald A. Hicks' homilies.

"I've been to several Masses that he has celebrated, and he is an excellent homilist," she said. "I've always wanted to clap after his homilies."

On Sunday, she got her chance. She clapped loudly along with hundreds of others after Hicks delivered his homily.

About 1,000 people applauded Hicks and gave him a standing ovation as he celebrated his final Mass as the Diocese of Joliet's bishop at St. Raymond in Joliet. Also present were roughly 100 priests from the diocese.

After the Mass, hundreds waited in a long line to have their photos taken with him.

Hicks is heading east to become the 11th archbishop of New York, a position he was appointed to last month by Pope Leo XIV. Hicks will be installed on Friday, Feb. 6, at St. Patrick's Cathedral, and between now and then he will transition into that role.

Joliet Diocese officials said there is no announcement for an interim bishop or a replacement and said those decisions are up to the Vatican.

Hicks has been Joliet's bishop since 2020. During Hicks' final homily as Joliet bishop, he talked about how throughout the years, he has asked people to pray for him, and he always prays for them.

"I have taken that commitment seriously each and every time," he said. "Please know that your prayers for me are one of the greatest gifts you have given to me."

"Right now, at this farewell Mass ... as all of you send me

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Forensic expert testimony excludes Yang as killer

A defense expert witness testified that Marni Yang is too short to have fired the bullets that killed the pregnant girlfriend of a former Chicago Bear in 2007.
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State extends open enrollment

Illinois is giving residents more time to shop for health insurance on the state's Affordable Care Act exchange, as Congress continues to tussle over whether to extend subsidies that reduce the cost of coverage. **Business**

Late tax bills have cost county schools \$122M



People enter the Cook County treasurer's office in downtown Chicago on Nov. 20. ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Districts took out loans to bridge revenue gap, school leaders say

By A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

Late property tax bills weren't just an inconvenience for homeowners and businesses, they were a drag on taxing districts around Cook County, to the collective tune of almost \$122 million for school districts alone, according to a group of suburban school leaders.

Bills that typically land in the summer weren't paid until mid-December thanks to a halting technology upgrade. Additional problems with the system

prevented the county from distributing those revenues to hundreds of taxing bodies.

To bridge the gap in the meantime, school districts — particularly wealthier ones whose budgets rely more heavily on property taxes than on state aid — had to take out loans, cash out investments or forgo other investment income that would have built up on property tax revenues parked in the bank, the Tribune previously reported.

According to a group of school leaders who have been surveying colleagues countywide, the interest and issuance cost of borrowing, plus cashed out and lost interest on

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TODAY'S WEATHER



High 48 Low 28

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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